fluent court Persian: ‘Whereas it has become apparent from recent events that the continuance of the British army in Afghanistan for the support of Shah Shuja-ool-Moolk is displeasing to the majority of the Afghan nation, and whereas the British government had no other object in sending troops to this country than the integrity, happiness and welfare of the Afghans, therefore it can have no wish to remain when that object is defeated by its presence.’ Then came the meat of Macnaghten’s draft treaty. ‘1st, the British troops now at Kabul will repair to Peshawar with all practical expedition, and thence return to India. 2nd, the Sirdars engage that the British troops shall be unmolested in their journey, shall be treated with all honour, and receive all possible assistance in carriage and provisions.’[99] It was at this point, noted Macnaghten in his last memo, that ‘Mahommed Akbar interrupted me and observed that we did not require supplies as there was no impediment to our marching the next morning. I mention the above fact to shew the impetuous disposition of this youth. He was reproved by the other Chiefs and he himself, except on this occasion, behaved with courtesy, though evidently elevated by his sudden change of fortune.’[100]

After two hours, an agreement was reached. The British were to withdraw three days later, on 14 December, and their safety was to be guaranteed. Captain Trevor was to be handed over as a hostage. Jalalabad, Ghazni and Kandahar would also be evacuated. In return for a large down-payment, food, grain and transport cattle would be sent to the British to help them on their way. Shah Shuja would be given the choice of leaving with the British or remaining in Kabul as a private citizen. The Bala Hisar would first be evacuated by its few remaining British officers and handed over to Akbar Khan. Meanwhile Dost Mohammad would be released from his house arrest in Ludhiana and allowed to return to the throne. The Afghans would undertake not to ally with any foreign power without the consent of the British, and the British in return promised that ‘the English army will not cross into Afghan territory unless the Afghan leaders request it’.

Macnaghten thought the terms as good as he was likely to get and, naive and delusional as ever, wrote to Auckland, ‘We shall part with the Afghans as friends, and I feel satisfied that any government which may be established hereafter will always be disposed to cultivate a good understanding with us.’[101]